

CUNY Beyond Phase 5 Progress: Global Search Schedule Handoff

Technical implementation record - August 21, 2026

Outcome

Phase 5 connects a planned course to the official CUNY Global Search without scraping live sections or claiming a fragile deep link is prefilled. Students can choose an administrator-verified term, course, modality preference, and time preference; receive exact BMCC-specific search instructions; copy the checklist; and open Global Search in a new tab while keeping the advising plan open.

Implemented architecture

The new provider-neutral `schedule_link_service.py` separates course parsing and institution mapping from the user interface. It returns a structured handoff object containing the official provider URL, normalized subject and catalog number, selected term, instructions, verification date, and disclaimer. The response explicitly sets `prefilled` to `false` because no documented stable deep-link parameter contract was found.

The `AcademicTerm` database model stores the term name, exact provider code, provider, verification timestamp, source URL, and activation state. Initial records are seeded from `docs/cuny_beyond_academic_terms.csv`, but seeding does not overwrite later administrator decisions.

Verified source data

The official Global Search interface was inspected on August 21, 2026. It displayed Borough of Manhattan CC and these term option values:

- 2026 Spring Term: 1262
- 2026 Summer Term: 1266
- 2026 Fall Term: 1269

Only 2026 Fall Term is active in the initial configuration. Past terms remain stored for auditability and are not shown to students.

Backend

- Public active-term endpoint.
- Public validated handoff endpoint.
- Admin-only all-term endpoint.
- Admin-only term-update endpoint.
- Fail-closed behavior for inactive terms, unknown campuses, and unparseable course placeholders.
- Reviewed institution labels for BMCC, Brooklyn College, City College, and John Jay College.
- Parsing support for ordinary, decimal, compact, and alphanumeric course codes.

Student interface

The authenticated `/schedule-handoff` page provides verified term selection, planned-course selection, modality and time preferences, a copyable checklist, and the official Global Search launch button. It explains that Global Search is for discovery and CUNYfirst is for registration.

Concrete remaining courses now receive **Find Sections** actions in both the degree-plan semester view and the major-change/transfer remaining-requirements view. Generic elective placeholders do not receive misleading search buttons.

Administrator interface

The admin dashboard links to `/admin/schedule-settings`. An administrator can inspect the provider code and verification date, activate or deactivate a term, update its reviewed label/code/date, and open the official source for manual verification.

Safety and limitations

The feature does not scrape section availability, submit searches, register a student, promise a seat, or bypass CUNYfirst. Modality and time are presented as filters for the student to apply. Prerequisites, holds, permissions, enrollment appointments, and live seat status remain controlling conditions.

Validation

Automated tests cover course normalization, decimal and alphanumeric catalog numbers, unmappable values, institution mapping, non-prefilled behavior, authenticated routes, admin connectivity, and Find Sections entry points. The full existing test suite is also run to protect curriculum and selector behavior.

Official source

CUNY Global Search: <https://globalsearch.cuny.edu/CFGlobalSearchTool/CFSearchToolController>